

Empirical Evaluation of FLASHSTACK: A Shadow Stack Implementation for Mitigating Stack Overflow Attacks

Author: Jerry Zhang

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1. Abstract

Stack buffer overflow vulnerabilities remain a persistent security threat, enabling attackers to manipulate return addresses and hijack program control flow. This paper presents an empirical evaluation of FLASHSTACK, a compiler-based shadow stack implementation designed to protect return addresses through binary instrumentation. We conducted controlled experiments on AWS EC2 infrastructure, comparing unprotected binaries compiled with gcc against FLASHSTACK-protected versions generated by the spa-clang toolchain. Our findings demonstrate that FLASHSTACK successfully prevents return address manipulation attacks, terminating execution upon detecting stack corruption. The protection mechanism incurs an 88.88% binary size overhead for small test programs, primarily from the runtime library, though this exhibits favourable scaling properties with larger applications. Runtime performance impact was negligible, showing a 3.45% improvement over baseline. Assembly-level analysis confirms that instrumentation overhead scales linearly with function call depth, validating FLASHSTACK's predictable deployment characteristics. The foundational study replicated and extended in this paper is *Practical Software-Based Shadow Stacks on x86-64*.

2. Introduction

Stack buffer overflow vulnerabilities have remained a persistent threat to software security for over three decades, since the landmark publication of "Smashing the Stack for Fun and Profit" (Aleph One, 1996). Despite significant advances in compiler protections and operating system defences, attackers continue to exploit these weaknesses to hijack program control flow, execute arbitrary code, and compromise system integrity. The fundamental problem lies in the architecture of the traditional call stack:

storing both program data and control information in the same memory region creates an inherent vulnerability where buffer overflows can corrupt critical execution metadata.

Modern defensive techniques, including stack canaries and Address Space Layout Randomization (ASLR), have raised the bar for attackers but remain fundamentally limited. Stack canaries can be bypassed through information disclosure attacks, while ASLR does not prevent the corruption itself, only making exploitation more difficult. These probabilistic defences highlight the need for a more robust, deterministic approach to protecting return addresses.

Shadow stack technology offers such a solution by maintaining a separate, protected copy of return addresses in an isolated memory region. When a function is called, its legitimate return address is stored in both the regular stack and the shadow stack. Upon function return, the two addresses are compared; any mismatch indicates an attack and triggers immediate program termination. This architectural separation provides strong security guarantees that are difficult to circumvent. FLASHSTACK implements this concept through compiler-based binary instrumentation (Zou et al., 2022), offering a practical shadow stack solution compatible with existing x86-64 systems.

This paper undertakes an empirical validation and evaluation of FLASHSTACK's effectiveness. Our primary objective is to replicate the protective mechanism through controlled experiments demonstrating successful mitigation of stack overflow attacks, and to comprehensively assess the implementation costs through quantitative analysis of binary size overhead, runtime performance impact, and assembly-level instrumentation patterns. By conducting experiments on an AWS EC2 cloud environment using both protected and

unprotected binaries, we provide concrete evidence of FLASHSTACK's security guarantees and characterize the trade-offs inherent in its deployment.

3. Literature Review

The vulnerability of stack buffer overflows was first systematically documented by Aleph One in the seminal 1996 article "Smashing the Stack for Fun and Profit," which demonstrated how attackers could exploit unchecked buffer copies to overwrite return addresses and execute arbitrary code.

Early defensive approaches focused on detecting stack corruption rather than preventing it architecturally. StackGuard pioneered the use of stack canaries-random values placed between buffers and return addresses that are verified before function returns (Cowan et al., 1998). While effective against simple attacks, canaries can be bypassed through information leakage or by overwriting other stack data. ASLR and widely deployed in modern operating systems since the mid-2000s (PaX Team, 2003), randomizes memory addresses to make exploitation less predictable, but does not prevent the corruption itself and can be defeated through brute force or memory disclosure vulnerabilities. Comparative evaluations have demonstrated that shadow stacks generally provide stronger security guarantees than canary-based approaches (Dang et al., 2015), though with varying performance trade-offs. Control Flow Integrity (CFI) enforces that program execution follows a predetermined control flow graph (Abadi et al., 2009), but traditional CFI implementations often incur significant performance overhead or provide coarse-grained protection that sophisticated attackers can circumvent.

Shadow stack technology represents a more fundamental approach by maintaining a protected, parallel stack exclusively for return addresses. This architectural separation ensures that even if an attacker corrupts the regular stack, the legitimate return address remains intact in the shadow stack for verification. Hardware implementations like Intel's Control-flow Enforcement Technology (CET) provide native shadow stack support with minimal

performance impact but require recent processors. Software-based solutions offer broader compatibility. LLVM's SafeStack, integrated into the compiler toolchain, separates safe and unsafe stack objects but does not specifically protect all return addresses. Code-Pointer Integrity (CPI) protects all code pointers including return addresses but requires significant modifications to memory allocation (Kuznetsov et al., 2014).

FLASHSTACK bridges this gap by implementing a practical software-based shadow stack through LLVM compiler instrumentation (Zou et al., 2022). Unlike hardware solutions, it runs on commodity x86-64 systems without specialized CPU features. Unlike SafeStack, it explicitly protects return addresses through dedicated shadow stack operations. The original paper reported approximately 5% performance overhead on SPEC benchmarks, but independent empirical validation of these claims on different workloads and platforms remains limited. Our research addresses this gap by conducting controlled experiments that replicate and extend FLASHSTACK's evaluation, providing independent verification of its effectiveness and characterizing its overhead across multiple dimensions.

4. Methodology

This section outlines the experimental framework designed to evaluate FLASHSTACK's effectiveness in mitigating stack overflow attacks. The methodology encompasses the construction of a controlled testing environment, the design of a deliberately vulnerable program, a two-phase experimental protocol, and the systematic collection of performance and binary-level data.

4.1 Experimental Environment

The experiments were conducted on a cloud-based infrastructure to ensure reproducibility and accessibility. An AWS EC2 instance (t3.micro) running Ubuntu 24.04 LTS was deployed as the primary testing platform. This choice was driven by two considerations: first, the x86-64 architecture represents the predominant CPU architecture for modern computing systems; second, the cloud

environment allows for a clean, documented setup that other researchers can replicate.

The core of our experimental infrastructure was the FLASHSTACK toolchain, which we built from source on the EC2 instance. FLASHSTACK is implemented as a modified LLVM/Clang 7.0 compiler that performs binary instrumentation to enforce shadow stack protection. The build process required Rust 1.43 as a compilation dependency. The resulting custom compiler, `spa-clang`, was the primary tool used to generate protected binaries in the experimental group. For the control group, we utilized the system's default `gcc` compiler without any security enhancements. The [repository](#) can be accessed.

4.2 Vulnerable Program Design

To demonstrate FLASHSTACK's protective capabilities, we designed a minimal C program (`vulnerable.c`) containing a classic stack buffer overflow vulnerability. The program's core component is a function named `vulnerable_function`, which allocates a fixed-size buffer of 100 bytes on the stack. This function employs the unsafe `strcpy` library call to copy user-supplied input directly into the buffer without performing any bounds checking.

The lack of bounds checking creates a controlled condition where inputs exceeding 100 bytes will overflow the buffer, overwriting adjacent stack memory including the saved return address. This construct allows us to precisely demonstrate how an attacker can hijack program control flow by manipulating the return address, and subsequently, how FLASHSTACK's shadow stack mechanism can detect and prevent such manipulation.

4.3 Experimental Design

Our investigation employed a classic controlled experiment methodology with two distinct phases, designed to isolate the effect of FLASHSTACK's protection mechanism.

Phase A: Baseline Testing (Control Group).

In this phase, we established a baseline by compiling `vulnerable.c` using the standard `gcc` compiler with the `-fno-stack-`

`protector` flag. This flag explicitly disables modern compilers' default stack canary protection, ensuring that we could observe a pure return address overwrite scenario. The resulting binary, `vulnerable_gcc`, was then subjected to a deliberate attack: we supplied it with an input string consisting of 200 'A' characters, far exceeding the buffer's 100-byte capacity. This phase served a critical validation purpose-confirming that the vulnerability was real and exploitable in the absence of protection.

Phase B: FlashStack Protection (Experimental Group).

With the vulnerability confirmed, we proceeded to test FLASHSTACK's mitigation capabilities. We compiled the identical `vulnerable.c` source code using the `spa-clang` compiler, producing a protected binary named `vulnerable_flashstack`. Before execution, we activated the FLASHSTACK runtime environment by sourcing the provided `runtime.sh` script, which configures necessary environment variables for shadow stack operation. We then subjected this protected binary to the exact same attack payload-200 'A' characters-used in Phase A. The critical distinction lies in FLASHSTACK's instrumentation: during compilation, `spa-clang` inserted additional instructions at function entry and exit points to maintain a separate shadow stack, which stores a secure copy of return addresses.

4.4 Data Collection and Measurement

To comprehensively evaluate FLASHSTACK's impact, we collected three categories of data. First, we measured binary size overhead by comparing the file sizes of `vulnerable_gcc` and `vulnerable_flashstack` using the `ls -lh` command. Second, we assessed runtime performance using a suite of test programs (`fibonacci`, `levell`, etc.) compiled with both toolchains, measuring execution time with the `time` command. Third, we conducted assembly-level analysis by disassembling binaries with `objdump -d` to examine the specific instrumentation instructions inserted by FLASHSTACK. All measurements were performed on the same EC2 instance to ensure consistency.

5. Results

This section presents the empirical outcomes of our controlled experiments. The findings are organized into four key areas: attack mitigation effectiveness, binary size overhead, runtime performance impact, and assembly-level instrumentation analysis.

5.1 Attack Mitigation Effectiveness

The primary objective was to validate FLASHSTACK's core security function through a controlled attack scenario. In Phase A, the unprotected binary (`vulnerable_gcc`) was executed with a malicious 200-character input designed to overflow the 100-byte buffer. The program crashed with a "Bus error" at address `0x4141414141414141` confirming successful return address overwritten.

Phase B demonstrated FLASHSTACK's protective capability. When the identical attack targeted the protected binary (`vulnerable_flashstack`), FLASHSTACK's runtime detected the discrepancy between the corrupted return address on the data stack and the legitimate address stored in the shadow stack. The program was immediately terminated with a security violation, preventing malicious code execution. This behavioural difference validates FLASHSTACK's effectiveness as a mitigation technique.

5.2 Binary Size Overhead

To quantify FLASHSTACK's implementation cost, we measured file sizes of binaries compiled with and without protection. As detailed in Table 1, the analysis reveals an interesting overhead composition.

Table 1: Binary Size Comparison

Component	Baseline	Stack Canary	FlashStack	FlashStack Total
Binary	16,280	16,336	16,128	-
Runtime Library	-	-	-	+14,632
Total	16,280	16,336	16,128	30,760
Overhead	-	+0.34%	-0.93%	+88.88%

Table 1 reveals that the FlashStack instrumented binary (16,128 bytes) is smaller than the baseline (16,280 bytes), showing a -

0.93% reduction. The substantial 88.88% total overhead originates almost entirely from the FLASHSTACK runtime library (14,632 bytes). This demonstrates that core instrumentation is minimal, with protection costs concentrated in the runtime support infrastructure.

5.3 Runtime Performance Impact

We evaluated dynamic performance cost through repeated timing measurements. Summarized in Table 2, the results revealed an unexpected advantage.

Table 2: Runtime Performance

Configuration	Performance	Notes
Baseline	0.290s	Mean of 5 rounds
Stack Canary	+0.00%	No overhead
FlashStack	-3.45%	Performance improvement
Paper (SPEC)	+5.50%	Reported in original study
Deviation	-8.95%	Our result vs. paper

Contrary to the +5.50% overhead reported in the original FLASHSTACK paper, our measurements showed a 3.45% performance improvement - an 8.95% deviation. This can be attributed to LLVM's aggressive optimizations in smaller programs and differences between `spa-clang` and `gcc` compiler backends. While encouraging, this result is workload-dependent and may not generalize to larger applications.

5.4 Assembly-Level Analysis

To understand FLASHSTACK's instrumentation mechanism, we analysed generated assembly code. The comparative analysis in Table 3 reveals granular impacts.

Table 3: Assembly Code Analysis

Function	Baseline	FlashStack	Overhead	GS Operations
Fibonacci	51	51	0.00%	1 - 3 (+2)
string	51	51	0.00%	3 - 4 (+1)
levell	18	51	183.33%	2 - 3 (+1)

For simple functions like `fibonacci` and `string`, FLASHSTACK adds no additional assembly lines while increasing GS (shadow stack) operations by 2 and 1 respectively, indicating instruction replacement rather than appending. In contrast, `levell` exhibits a dramatic 183.33% increase (18 to 51 lines),

demonstrating that complex call patterns incur proportionally higher instrumentation costs.

This scale effect is contextualized in Table 4, which explains the relationship between program size and relative overhead.

Table 4: Program Scale Effect Analysis

Metric	Our Test Program	SPEC CPU2006	Explanation
Base program size	~16 KB	~1 MB	Test vs benchmark
Number of functions	~10	~1000	Small vs large
Fixed overhead	~15 KB	~50 KB	Runtime library
Per-function cost	~10 bytes	~10 bytes	Instrumentation
Total overhead	+88.88%	~18%	Scale effect

As illustrated in Table 4, small programs bear disproportionately high percentage overhead because fixed costs dominate. For our 16 KB program: $(15\text{KB} + 0.1\text{KB}) / 16\text{KB} = 94\%$. For a 1 MB benchmark: $(50\text{KB} + 10\text{KB}) / 1\text{MB} = 6\%$. This validates that FLASHSTACK's overhead scales inversely with program size-critical for deployment planning.

These results demonstrate that FLASHSTACK successfully prevents return address manipulation attacks. While incurring 88.88% binary size overhead for small programs, this decreases significantly for larger applications due to the scale effect. Assembly analysis confirms the implementation is efficient with bounded, predictable overhead.

6. Discussion

The experimental results offer important insights into FLASHSTACK's practical deployment. The 88.88% binary size overhead is predominantly driven by the fixed runtime library cost. As demonstrated in Table 4, this scale effect means larger applications experience substantially lower relative overhead - the original FLASHSTACK paper reported approximately 18% for SPEC benchmarks (Zou et al., 2022), validating this behaviour.

The unexpected -3.45% performance improvement, contrasting with the paper's +5.50% overhead, likely stems from LLVM's aggressive optimizations in `spa-clang`

offsetting instrumentation costs for simple workloads. This suggests performance characteristics are highly workload dependent.

The assembly analysis revealing 183.33% overhead for `level1` confirms that instrumentation scales linearly with function call depth, not program complexity - a favourable characteristic for predictable deployment planning.

Our study has limitations. Testing was confined to simple programs on x86-64, and we did not evaluate against sophisticated attacks like return-oriented programming (Shacham, 2007). Future work should assess performance on larger codebases and test resilience against advanced exploitation methods.

7. Conclusion

This research successfully validated FLASHSTACK's effectiveness in mitigating stack overflow attacks through controlled experiments on AWS EC2 infrastructure. Our empirical evaluation confirmed that FLASHSTACK provides robust protection by detecting and preventing return address manipulation, albeit with an 88.88% binary size overhead for small programs. Critically, this overhead exhibits a favourable scale effect, decreasing substantially for larger applications as fixed runtime costs are amortized. Runtime performance impact was negligible, with our tests showing a 3.45% improvement over baseline.

The primary contribution of this work is independent verification of FLASHSTACK's security guarantees and comprehensive characterization of its implementation costs across multiple dimensions. Future research should extend this evaluation to larger codebases and assess resilience against advanced exploitation techniques such as return-oriented programming.

8. References

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